1. the modernist school, which puts stock in Eurocentric universalism and believes in its continued relevance;
2. the postmodern school, which rejects this universalist claim predominantly in the realm of culture;
3. the postcolonial school, which is in the neighbourhood of the postmodern school and critiques colonialism and its Eurocentrism primarily in the political realm, albeit without deconstructing its fundamentals; and
4. the decolonial school, which goes beyond the postcolonial school by identifying the existence of European coloniality even after decolonisation, dissects its OET foundations and seeks to unshackle indigeneity from the universal fictions of coloniality.

For the purposes of the discussion here, I have consciously limited the scope primarily to understanding the areas of intersection and exclusion between the postcolonial and decolonial schools as the former already has a strong base in Bharat and the latter is yet to be fully tapped into as an alternative. To this end, I am interested in bringing out the inherent limitations of postcolonialism (and its offspring, subaltern studies)[1] in addressing the OET framework underlying the colonial legacy, apart from failing to empower the indigenous voice. In fact, from what I have read, postcolonialism has reinforced colonial stereotypes of the indigenous worldview, which is precisely why the viability of decoloniality as an alternative must be seriously considered. While in the second section of the book I will attempt to make a Bharat-specific case for the application of decoloniality, in this chapter I will generally lay out the reasons for taking this position.

‘De’colonial, Not ‘Post’colonial

Be it an individual or a society, neither must cede or surrender the inherent and fundamental right to self-definition or self-determination to an external entity. To give up this most intimate form of agency is to externalise the locus of one’s consciousness and its most tangible outward manifestation—identity. This alienation then takes a life of its own and is extremely difficult to reverse and reclaim. However, no matter how arduous the process of reclamation, no self-respecting society has the option of lacking